The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

America and **Israel** continued to strike Iran as attacks on infrastructure intensified across the Middle East. The attacks targeted oil facilities in and around Iran's capital, Tehran. Meanwhile an Israeli strike killed at least four people in a hotel in the centre of Beirut, the capital of Lebanon. Israel said it had struck 3,400 targets in Iran since the war began, and 600 in Lebanon.

Iran expanded its missile and drone attacks across the region. **Bahrain's** foreign ministry bemoaned indiscriminate "Iranian aggression" and said a water-desalination plant had been hit by a drone. An Iranian drone strike also set alight a government building in **Kuwait**. The **United Arab Emirates** said Iran had launched more strikes against its territory, and warned it would take "all necessary measures" to protect itself.

Members of **Iran's** assembly of experts, a group of 88 clerics, said they had picked a successor to Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the country's **supreme leader** who was killed in American and Israeli strikes on February 28th. They did not name their choice publicly. Khamenei's son, Mojtaba Khamenei, who is close to the security services, is thought to be a front-runner.

Britain's foreign secretary, Yvette Cooper, defended the approach of the prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, to the Iran war, saying the government should avoid "outsourcing" foreign policy to other countries. Earlier, Mr Trump accused Britain of trying to join the war "after we've already won". Sir Keir originally refused America's request to use its bases for attacks on Iran, before relenting a little.

China's foreign minister said **America's** war with **Iran** "should not have happened" and called for its "immediate" end. But Wang Yi suggested China still sought to arrange a meeting between Mr Trump and China's leader, Xi Jinping; he noted that failure to maintain dialogue between the countries would lead to "misunderstandings and misjudgments". The summit is expected to take place at the end of March.

Balendra Shah looked set to become **Nepal's** prime minister after preliminary results showed his Rastriya Swatantra Party claimed a big election victory. Mr Shah unseated the previous PM, Sharma KP Oli, having stood against him in his parliamentary constituency. In September a student-led revolution forced Mr Oli to stand down. Mr Shah's RSP attracted young voters unhappy with establishment parties.

One of **OpenAI's** top researchers resigned following the firm's controversial deal with the Pentagon. Caitlin Kalinowski, who heads OpenAI's robotics team, cited her fears that, under the agreement, artificial intelligence would be used to develop autonomous weapons and prompt the "surveillance of Americans without judicial oversight". OpenAI insists it has provisions in place to mitigate such use. Anthropic, a rival, walked away from a similar deal.

Word of the week: *hujjat al-islam*, an Islamic title equivalent to a middle-ranking Christian priest. Read our obituary of Ali Khamenei.

Photograph: Marijan Murat/dpa

A fear-fuelled election in Germany's car hub

An election in Baden-Württemberg on Sunday kicks off Germany's *Superwahljahr*, a "super election year" in which five of the country's 16 states go to the polls. The centre-right Christian Democrats (CDU) hope to unseat the Greens, who have run the south-western state, one of Germany's largest, for 15 years. But the CDU's polling lead has evaporated in recent weeks. Cem Özdemir, the Green candidate and the son of Turkish guest workers, could become Germany's first-ever state premier with an immigrant background. A loss for the CDU would be a disaster for Friedrich Merz, Germany's conservative chancellor.

Economic anxiety has shaped the campaign in one of Europe's richest regions. Home to Mercedes, Porsche and countless car suppliers, Baden-Württemberg built its prosperity around a technology—the internal combustion engine—facing obsolescence. Lay-offs have inspired (exaggerated) fears that Stuttgart, the state capital, could become a second Detroit. Aiming to capitalise on the angst, the hard-right Alternative for Germany may achieve its best-ever result in a western German state.

Photograph: Shutterstock

Colombia’s centrists eye a comeback

Colombians vote in legislative elections on Sunday. The race for Congress has already been marred by violence and allegations of vote-buying. To maintain order, authorities have banned alcohol sales from Saturday night.

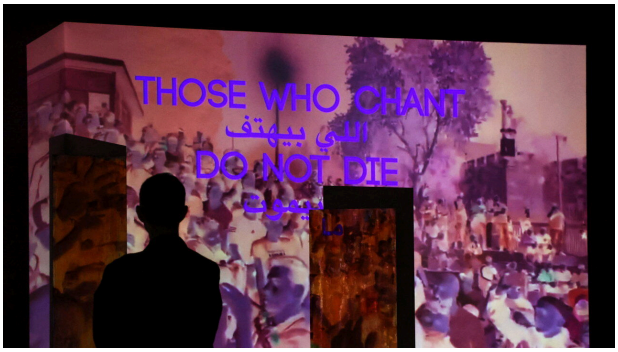
People will also vote in three presidential primaries. Sixteen candidates feature, split into coalitions representing the left, centre and right. The winner could lead their party into the first round of the election in May, but not before negotiating with the three most popular candidates, who are not on Sunday’s ballot. (The constitution prevents the left-wing incumbent, Gustavo Petro, from re-election.) They are Iván Cepeda, a left-wing senator barred from running on technical grounds; Sergio Fajardo, a centrist former mayor of Medellín, who is running independently; and Abelardo de la Espriella, a polemical criminal lawyer and political outsider. Many are watching Claudia López, a centrist ex-mayor of Bogotá, the capital, who has risen in polls. Her showing may indicate whether centrism can stage a comeback in a polarised country.

Photograph: Getty Images

All change in F1

An element of mystery surrounds the first race of a Formula One season. After a winter of testing, fans and pundits are never quite sure how the cars will run. But there *was* even less certainty than usual ahead of the 2026 season, which began on Sunday in Melbourne, and not just because of the travel disruption caused by the war in the Middle East.

The sport’s governing body enforced a host of new rules, which include making the cars shorter, narrower and lighter. It is also insisting on hybrid engines powered by electricity as well as internal combustion. Meanwhile, two new carmaking giants entered the fray. Audi, owned by Volkswagen, has taken over the Sauber team, and Cadillac is joining the grid in a new venture part operated by General Motors. For now, neither is likely to challenge for the podium. George Russell of Mercedes won in Melbourne, ahead of his teammate, Kimi Antonelli.



Photograph: Reuters

A contemplative Whitney Biennial

For decades the Biennial at the Whitney Museum of American Art in New York has surveyed the state of the country's art. The exhibition that opens this weekend falls in America's bisesquicentennial (250th) year, already one of turmoil.

The works on show explore themes such as technology, conflict and climate change. The experience is immersive. In "Pandemonium", a digital projection by Michelle Lopez, newspaper clippings, the American flag and debris whirl across the ceiling while violins screech. An oil painting by Ali Eyal portrays an amusement park in Baghdad, the city of his birth, which he left shortly before the Iraq war in 2003. Oswaldo Maciá uses scent and sound to celebrate extinct insects. The museum says the exhibition is a display of "togetherness through difference". It asks visitors to consider what makes art "American"—and offers no simple answers.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

They all gave the correct answers of:

Skyler Hutto, Orangeburg, South Carolina, America
Hélène Tremblay, Gatineau, Canada
Vince Sinclair, Godalming, Britain

The questions were: Daily Express, The Signal and the Noise, conductors, platform shoes and a track. The theme is railways (railroads) which have express trains, signals, conductors, platforms and tracks

Monday: Which British newspaper, when owned by Lord Beaverbrook, had the largest circulation in the world in the 1940s?
Tuesday: Which book by Nate Silver, published in 2012, is about the art of interpreting statistics?
Wednesday: Arturo Toscanini, Leopold Stokowski and Claudio Abbado all achieved fame in what role?
Thursday: What type of footwear, which raised the user's height, was very popular in the 1970s?
Friday: What musical term refers to both an individual song on an album and an isolated channel from a single instrument that is mixed with others to make a recording?

The great nations have always acted like gangsters, and the small nations like prostitutes.

Stanley Kubrick